Chauhan is now on shaky ground in the BJP. So is Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP) chief O.P. Rajbhar. Also rejoining the NDA in July, he had put his reputation at stake in the Ghosi campaign. The Rajbhar community has a sizeable presence in this pocket of Purvanchal, and the loss has deflated his claims of having a "transferable vote bank". Both leaders had made tall claims about helping the BJP sweep the non-Yadav OBC votes. The Noniya Chauhan and Rajbhar communities together command nearly 100,000 votes in the constituency, while dominant castes number around 75,000. The combination should have proved a formidable force for the BJP. But none of that happened—no vote transfer, no automatic OBC vote migration along with the leader. The party may not give up on either leader—it's too close to the general election, and Purvanchal had been a weak link for it in the 2022 assembly election. Sources close to Chauhan claim he has met the BJP central leadership and demanded an MLC berth to enter the assembly. Rajbhar, too, has apparently put forth his defences to the bosses in New Delhi.

The result has expectedly brought a spring to the step of Opposition stalwarts. Shivpal Yadav, SP general secretary and uncle of party chief Akhilesh Yadav, has redeemed himself—he had been given charge of the Ghosi bypolls and had been camping there. Analysts are also looking at the role of the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), which decided to give the Ghosi contest a pass. Says academic Dr Shilp Shikha Singh, "If the BSP had fielded a candidate, things would have been different. The party has a presence in Ghosi. It seems a large chunk of the Dalit vote has gone in favour of Sudhakar, who is from a forward caste. This trend should set off alarm bells in the BJP—that in the absence of the BSP, Dalit votes can shift to the INDIA bloc."

The Ghosi result could put pressure on the BSP to join INDIA. A senior BSP leader, on condition of anonymity, says, "Our cadre voting for the INDIA bloc means now they are choosing to vote only for an anti-BJP force. This is an alarming situation for us." The result will also boost the Opposition's belief that the BJP is not invincible in UP. If INDIA comes up with a winning caste combination worthy of its alliance, they could provide a few shocks to the BJP in 2024. ■



ANI

▲ **SPARKLING WIN** SP supporters celebrate the victory in Ghosi



By Amarnath K. Menon

If Hyderabad hosted a Congress Working Committee meeting on September 16-17, followed by a party rally on the city's outskirts, the significance of the choice of venue was not lost on anyone. These were grand preparatory gestures, heralding the Grand Old Party's campaign to rediscover itself as a ruling force in Telangana—the state it had helped create. As the party that led the UPA, it was the Congress that had taken the initiative and adopted the legislation in Parliament for the formation of the separate state in 2014. But it had had to suffer the ignominy of losing the assembly poll that year to a regional party, the Telangana Rashtra Samithi (now the Bharat Rashtra Samithi or BRS). It lost in 2018 too, and practically vanished from the political map in its former stronghold. This time, it's determined to wrest the state back from Chief Minister K. Chandrashekar Rao (KCR) in the assembly election due at the end of the year.

At the rally, former Congress president Sonia Gandhi announced the first of the six guarantees (6G) the party will implement if voted to power. "We will introduce the Mahalakshmi scheme offering a grant of Rs 2,500 to all women, supply of LPG cylinders at